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The crematorium on Nelson Manickam Road.
PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGMENT



Nungambakkam crematorium sports a new look

The facility has received an additional gasifier, a decade-long request

S. KASTURI RANGAN

Greater Chennai Corporation's crematorium on Nelson Manickam Road in Nungambakkam is looking sharp, having been imparted a new look by a massive makeover.

With the redevelopment exercise spanning eight months having run its course, the facility was reopened a few weeks ago.

GCC officials point out the work was carried out at a cost of ₹1.5 crore allocated under Thousand Lights MLA Local Area Development Fund.

The work features a verdant landscape to the facility with sprawling lawns, trees, and flowering plants.



The decades-old dilapidated buildings that housed the furnace and where the last rites were performed have been demolished and new ones with good ventilation have been constructed.

Paver block walkways lead to these buildings. Adequate number of benches and lights have been provided. All these impart a serene and tranquil ambience to the crematorium. Earlier, the place was unkempt and in a rundown state.

Because, Greater Chennai Corporation was using the crematorium as a waste segregation point.

The place used to stink. For many years, residents have been requesting GCC to refrain from using the crematorium for waste management purpose.

Further the broken compound walls gave room for illegal activities.

We are happy to note that the renovation work has put an end to all those issues.

Next, an additional gasifier has been provided as part of the redevelopment exercise. It may be noted this crematorium witnesses a good patronage. In addition to residents of Nungambakkam and Choolaimedu, those from Spur Tank Road in Egmore, North Usmaan Road - T Nagar, and Amnjikarai near Anna Nagar also use this crematorium.

So an additional facility was badly needed.

This was a decade-long request of the local residents and that has been honoured now. The crematorium falls in Ward 110 of Zone 9 - Teynampet.

S. Kasturi Rangan is the secretary of Choolaimedu Exnora Innovators Club, Choolaimedu

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'Inaccessible' parks in Iyyappanthangal

P. SENTHIL KUMAR

In Iyyappanthangal Village Panchayat, parks raised on the Open Space Reservation (OSR) lands of multi-storey gated communities are not accessible to the general public from the roads. One has to enter the gated community to access the park.

There are three such notable parks: two on Oil Mill Road and the third one on EVP Park Avenue. But none of them can be accessed from

these roads. One of these parks have a small gate on Oil Mill Road but is always locked.

Further, the general public is not even aware of the existence of these parks as their name boards are located inside the gated communities.

It may be noted that in response to my complaint to the Chief Minister's Cell a year ago, the Block Development Office – Kundrathur directed the residents' associations of the gated communities to take

necessary steps to ensure the general public make use of these parks. But to this day, a larger section of the public are not even aware of these parks' existence and my complaint to the CM's Cell remains unaddressed.

P. Senthil Kumar is a resident of Iyyappanthangal

The name boards shown in the images are of Iyyappanthangal Village Panchayat's parks on Oil Mill Road. And they are kept inside the apartments. The general public cannot take note of them. The image (top left) shows the compound wall of the park with no entrance gate. And the image (bottom right) shows a tiny gate to the OSR park that can be easily missed.

'Uneven road raises the risk of accidents'



Arcot Road near Lakshmi Nagar bus stop in Valasaravakkam. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

R. KALIDURAI

The section of Arcot Road near Lakshmi Nagar bus stop in Valasaravakkam is uneven. This is a result of poor road laying work carried out two months ago. Only a part of

the road's width was laid and the remaining portion has not been done yet and this has caused a noticeable height difference making it difficult for road users, especially motorcyclists.

It is a struggle to change lanes due to the unevenness and with

the heavy flow of vehicles during peak hours, the risk of accidents is high. There are no signboards to caution the motorists about the danger lurking at this spot.

R. Kalidurai is a resident of Valasaravakkam

Citizens group seeks bus service to Pozhichalur

R.K. RAVICHANDRAN

Bus services connecting Iyyappanthangal and Pozhichalur via Gerugambakkam are needed. We are seeking this facility to access Tambaram quickly.

At present, Metropolitan Transport Corporation operates a service connecting Iyyappanthangal and Tambaram routed via Porur, Kundrathur and Pammal. The frequency of this bus route called, 166, is poor. Further, it takes an hour-and-a-half to reach Tambaram. Now, due to the ongoing road work in Kundrathur, this duration is further increased.

Hence, we are seeking buses to Pozhichalur from where there are many buses to Tambaram at a good frequency. Such a service will help us save 20 minutes.

R.K. Ravichandran is the founder and president of Iyyappanthangal Bharaniputhur Consumer Rights Protection Society.

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Art exhibition at Cathedral Road

The three-day exhibition happening at Kalpa Druma concludes on March 23

Thooriga, a collective of four women artists, is having its seventh art exhibition till March 23 at Kalpa Druma, Cathedral Road, Gopalapuram.

Each exhibition of Thooriga celebrates Tamil Nadu's rich cultural heritage, the beauty of nature, and the strength and grace of women in art.

In its previous editions, Thooriga has captivated audiences through a unique blend of individual creativity and collaborative spirit, said a release. The show will feature artworks by Gayathri Balaji, Yamuna Bala, Sathya N. Prabhu, and Charanya Rajesh. They explore themes that connect tradition, spirituality, storytelling, and the inner strength of human experience.

Charanya Rajesh's works celebrate the spiritual symbolism of



women, drawing inspiration from Indian scriptures and portraying the beauty, courage, and compassion of women. Sathya N. Prabhu's artworks invite viewers into a reflective journey that bridges past and present, creating emotional connections through artistic expression. Gayathri Balaji's paintings draw deeply from epic narratives, portraying vivid moments through traditional artistic tech-

niques. Yamuna Bala's works explore the immense inner strength, resilience, and potential within every human being.

The event is supported by the Department of Art and Culture, Government of Tamil Nadu, which provides sponsorships to promote artists through group and solo exhibitions, added the release. The initiative was announced in January 2026.



▼ The group and some of their artworks.



Award presented to senior optometrist

Ramani Krishnakumar, an eminent optometrist, received the 'Doyen of Indian Optometry: Lifetime Achievement Award in Community Eye Care and Academic Excellence' from TwinTech Healthcare Academy recently.

The award, instituted on the oc-

casion of World Optometry Day (observed annually on March 23), was presented this year at a special event held on March 20 in recognition of Dr. Krishnakumar's three decades of dedicated service in optometry, education, and community eye care, said a release.

Dr Ramani currently serves as

president of the Ophthalmic Sciences Professional Council under NCAHP, Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, Government of India. He has played a pivotal role in strengthening optometric education, advancing professional standards, and mentoring generations of eye care professionals across the

country, said the release.

The award was presented by Dr. P. P. Santanam, first principal of Elite School of Optometry and a pioneer in occupational optometry in India, who graced the occasion as chief guest.

A. Mahalingam, managing director, TwinTech Healthcare Academy along with faculty members, optometrists, and distinguished guests, participated in the event.

Aavin Women's Welfare Society distributes aid



Members of Aavin Women's Welfare Society (AWWS) celebrated International Women's Day at Pasumpon Devar Mandapam on Habibullah Road in T. Nagar on March 9, 2026.

On behalf of AWWS, Aavin Managing Director John Louis gifted ₹2.39 lakh worth of aid to Visharanti Old Age Home (Home for Visually Challenged) and Salvation Trust, says a press release.

R. Sivakami Sundari, president, AWWS welcomed the gathering.

S. Revathi, treasurer, AWWS delivered the vote of thanks.

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A data jam on March 28 will have participants studying how the Assembly constituencies in and around Chennai are faring on a set of parameters

LIFFY THOMAS

If data is a key factor for you to assess your constituency's performance then this event is for you. OpenCity, a civic tech platform that makes data easy to find, access, share and analyse is hosting a data jam on March 28 at Bhumi in Alwarpet to gauge how the city fared in parameters such as health, education, public transport, civic engagement and performance of the MLAs in the 20 Assembly constituencies in and around Chennai.

Data jam is not new to Chennai. OpenCity (a programme of the Oorvani Foundation) has in the past conducted similar workshops to study urban heat, lakes and flooding, and this one is planned to give participants a better understanding of the performance of the different constituencies ahead of the Assembly elections.

Here people from diverse professional backgrounds work in groups to understand how data can be used to understand civic issues plaguing the city.

Data available in the public domain is shared with participants and they analyse, brainstorm to get a better understanding of the issues and also give solutions.

For example, data from different databases and portals such as www.dge.tn.gov.in and UDISE will be used to get information on the number of government schools in an area, students enrolled and the count of teachers.

"Participants correlate to find what is lacking in every constituency," says Vaidya R., programme lead, Oorvani Foundation.

In 2024, the organisers used satellite data to understand ur-



A 'jamming' session ahead of TN elections

ban heat in different localities of Chennai. For instance, Koyamedu Metro was one of the hottest spots. In the part of Chennai it is located, Perungudi dumping ground topped the charts for extremely hot conditions.

The significance

"Either through maps put out by Greater Chennai Corporation or through their own experiences, participants correlated urban heat area," says Vaidya.

In some of the data jams, stakeholders take part in them or the findings are shared with them. The data jam on urban heat was presented to CMDA.

"A stakeholder could be a civic group working on the ground, and they could include the findings in petitions they submit to government departments," says Vaidya.

OpenCity has conducted data jams in all major metros and is happy these events offer people a platform to share their experiences. In Bangalore, a participant went on to develop a tool to measure the "public transport affinity" for a given area.

The data jam is being conducted in partnership with Citizen Consumer and Civic Action Group, Reach the Unreached and Nagariyal. For details, visit <https://forms.gle/cUIdseNvY-Yx4PWL78> or scan the QR code



'Data is a weapon'

Tambaram resident Raju K, working with a research agency, uses data to take up issues he feels strong about. In his mid-20s, Raju attended a data jam on lakes conducted by OpenCity; since then, he has been hugely curious about data jams.

A volunteer with Chennai Wetlands Action Collective and Save Madambakkam Lake Committee, Raju says OpenCity is a one-stop place to find data about a number of things.

For instance, for Save Madambakkam Lake Committee, they were able to get different data in the portal and use it in GIS maps and observe what the violations were.

"The data about the elevation of residential area, the lake and the real estate development next to the lake helped us get the real picture and petition various government authorities and seek action. We also found that as due to the difference in height, surface run-off water could not enter the lake and would inundate the existing residential area," he says.

Another example of using data is to analyse why certain areas get more inundated. "We studied 2015 inundation map and an earlier one to analyse Porur lake's catchment area. Urbanisation and SWDs not being interconnected were among reasons why inundation was common in this belt," he says.



Calcutta, I'm Sorry wants to be on OTT

Global Anglo-Indian Network (GAIN) has started a petition to help take Chennai resident Harry MacLure's latest film to a global audience

LIFFY THOMAS

Chennai-based Harry MacLure, a well-known face of the Anglo-Indian community, is drumming up support for the release of his latest film *Calcutta, I'm Sorry* on OTT platforms.

Global Anglo-Indian Network (GAIN) has started a petition on Change.org asking people to support the campaign and showcase the talented, spirited people who have been part of the film.

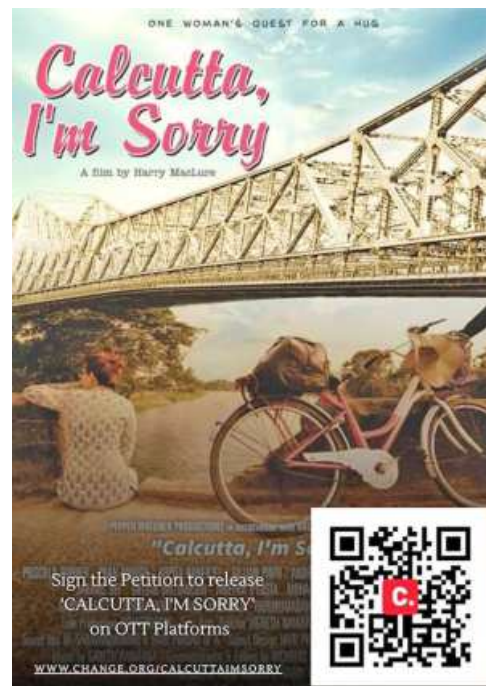
Harry, who has scripted and directed the film, is a board member of GAIN. *Calcutta, I'm Sorry* is centred around Anglo-Indian characters, but is not a story about the Anglo-Indian community *per se* but

brings out the essence of being Anglo-Indian. Featuring Priscilla Corner, who plays the protagonist Amanda Wright diagnosed with multiple sclerosis, the film takes viewers on an emotional road trip from Coonoor to Kolkata on a trusty bicycle to to meet her granddaughter.

The work on the movie began in 2019, but pandemic and other challenges delayed its theatrical release. In 2022, Harry and team completed the post production of the film that runs to one hour and 52 minutes.

"Usually a movie is released in theatres and then someone comes forward to buy it and put it on an OTT platform, which did not happen in the case of this film," says Harry, who has started the petition to get more signatures so that it draws the attention of OTT platforms.

Besides showcasing the artistic talent of the Anglo-Indian community, the film has a powerful



The film takes viewers on an emotional road trip from Coonoor to Kolkata on a bicycle.

message from a lady with multiple sclerosis.

The petition reads, "This film beautifully captures the essence of our journey, moving through themes of family, search and redemption as it follows a determined woman's journey on a bicycle. It is a story of a woman's quest for a hug from a granddaughter she has never met, representing the deep emotional roots and resilience of our people."

By supporting this campaign, you are helping us amplify voices that have remained on the periphery for too long, the note adds.

Special screening

In the last few years, Harry has been screening the film for select groups. The Multiple Sclerosis So-

ciety of India, Chennai chapter, had a special screening of the film in 2024.

Recently, a Malayalam film distributor who liked the film said the movie would do well in Malayalam and wanted Harry to dub it.

"But I am hesitant, how can an Anglo-Indian story where we speak in English do well in Malayalam?" he wonders.

Filmmaking is not new to Harry who also is editor of *Anglos In The Wind*, a magazine for the community. In 2013, he directed *Going Away*, a film about the community's migration to foreign lands.

The petition adds: "Help us showcase the talented bunch we are and ensure the world truly knows us through our films."

Visit <https://c.org/CSwSdX7Djv>.



Workshop on wedding photography

Entrepreneurship Development & Innovation Institute, a Department of MSME - Tamil Nadu is conducting a training programme on wedding photography and video editing from March 23 to 27. For details, call 8668102600/8754495254.

Making incense sticks

The institute is also conducting another workshop on making incense sticks, camphor, and candles from March 24

to 26. The session will also focus on making rose water and detergents meant for cleaning brass and silver articles. Both liquid and power detergents will be taught, says a press release. For details, call 9360221280 / 98401 14680.

Both the workshops will be held at the institute's premises at EDII Office Road, Ekkattuthangal. Time: From 10 a.m. to 5 p.m. Prior registration is mandatory. Those 18 years of age and above can take part.

Yoga workshop

Satyananda Yoga Centre of Satyam Yoga Trust is conducting a four-week Yoga programme from March 22 at the following venues: Sri Ayyappan & Sri Goshala Krishnan Temple, Sri Sashta Sangam, 89, Pon-nambalam Salai, K.K.Nagar; Shri Sudarshan Terrace Hall, B-2, Lakshmi Nagar Main Road, Nanganallur; Sri

Vengili Amman Temple, Madambakkam Main Road, Madambakkam; and Satyananda Yoga Centre, Murugu Nagar, Velachery.

Classes will be held from 5.30 a.m. to 7 a.m.

According to a press release, no fee will be charged. The centre follows Bihar School of Yoga. Sessions on food habits and mantra recitation are part of the programme. For details, call 94450 51015.

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